MCP

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Rush Hour

Author:
Stephanie Christensen

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By Stephanie Christensen

[Enter Jasmine, texting on her phone, looking for her Rideshare car. She is late for work. Jasmine's phone makes a noise, getting a notification. She looks up to see her car pull up. She climbs into the car.]

Jasmine: Hello! I'm Jasmine. White Honda Accord, right? **[pauses, as if listening, nods]** Yes, yeah, I know this is a Quick Ride Carpool. You can pick up anyone along the way, but just so you know, I am running late. **[waves $1 bill around]** And maybe Mr. George Washington can convince you to skip some passengers. **[dejected, mumbles]** Fine… **[Phone rings and she picks up]**

Yeah? Yeah, look, Taylor, I am on my way to work. **[looks shiftily at driver, whispers]** …this numbskull Quick Ride driver won't skip any other passengers. **[overdramatic]** I *know,* right?! Even the one-dollar bill trick didn't work. **[jerks forward, makes a face at driver]** Hold on, we just stopped. Yeah, we're picking someone else up.

Cary Anne [to driver]: HELLO, sweet angel, thank you for picking me up! I can't navigate a flamingo from a pigeon in this big city. That's what I get for moving to the Big Apple, huh?

Jasmine [surprised, displeased]: Cary Anne?!

Cary Anne [super excited]: Oh my gosh, Jasmine! You darling busy bee! My morning just keeps getting better.

Jasmine: And mine's right up there with kidney stones. Just a second. **[back to phone]** Taylor, I have to go. My brother's…colorful… girlfriend just got in the car. *Yeah.* Bye. **[hangs up, murmurs]** Some*one*'s getting 1 star today.

Cary Anne: Oh Jasmine, are you getting any sleep? Poor thing. Those are some dark bags under your eyes.

Jasmine: Excuse me. **[blinks in shock]** That was really rude?!

Cary Anne: What??? I never said they weren't designer. They could be Gucci.

Jasmine: This is just my luck. When my brother plucked you out of the armpit of Timbuktu—

Cary Anne: Oh, not Timbuktu— Arkansas!

Jasmine [stunned]: This is the worst day ever. Didn't Josh tell you that New Yorkers were grumpy in the morning?

Cary Anne: Oh, Josh isn't grumpy in the morning! Quite the opposite, I find he's actually more sprite and daring in the morning, if you know what I mean.

Jasmine: EWW! STOP. Josh is my brother. Do you get why I wouldn't want to KNOW THAT?

Cary Anne: don't do that grumpy thing, Jaz. I know that there's a compassionate, divine soul somewhere deep down in you.

Jasmine: Don't call me Jaz. Only my friends call me Jaz.

Cary Anne: Come on! We could be friends. I've seen your brother naked.

Jasmine: EW!

Cary Anne: I'm just saying. If I can love every imperfect part of him, I can love you too. Every part of you.

Jasmine: Every part of me?

Cary Anne [gasps]: That's not what I meant!

Jasmine [grabs Carry Anne's hands sweetly]: Maybe in another life, Carry Anne. When you're not dating my brother.

Cary Anne: That's… **[leans forward to driver]** Just so you know, that is not what I meant.

Jasmine: Okay, let the driver know little miss Arkansas is not homosexual. *That's* not homophobic.

Cary Anne: You know I am very accepting of the multi-sexual community. Heck, who am I to judge! I'm with the man I love. Can you say the same?

Jasmine: Love is an overrated concept. It's left me cold and dull inside. To be honest, I'm over that part of my life.

Cary Anne: Over love? How can you be over love?

Jasmine: It's just too hard meeting the right person.

Cary Anne: Oh come on! You can meet the right person anywhere. Like, at a stoplight perhaps?

Jasmine [scoffs]: Come on, what is that supposed to—

[Jasmine is cut off by Cary Anne leaning over her to lower the window and wave at a group of attractive young men in the car next to them]

Cary Anne [yelling]: HEEEYY!! HEY BOYS, OVER HERE! Yeah that's right, I'm talking to you, Sideburns. My friend here is looking for a boyfriend. She says hi, isn't that right, Jazzy?

Jasmine: Cary Anne, STOP IT! **[pushes Cary Anne off her]** *Stop it*. **[turns to window, and discretely does the call me sign so Cary Anne doesn't see]** …call me.

Cary Anne: Now what did I say?

Jasmine: That was so embarrassing, Cary Anne! **[both look at each other and laugh]** …Well. You pushed me out of my comfort zone.

Cary Anne: That's why your brother loves me.

Jasmine: Why aren't you with him, by the way?

Cary Anne: what do you mean?

Jasmine: He has a car. It's no Lamborghini, but it works.

Cary Anne: You can say that again. **[a bit flustered]** but no, I was just with him…

[Jasmine eyes her suspiciously]

Cary Anne: We were just at brunch. You know, that gourmet bacon place?

Jasmine [hungry]: Oh my… bacon…

Cary Anne: Mhmm… and their virgin mimosa are marvelous too. Josh was late for work, so he took the car, and called a Quick Ride Carpool to get me home.

Jasmine [mega suspicious now]: Oh yeah? I think you maybe had one too many mimosas, because this car is going nowhere near your guys' house.

Cary Anne: *virgin* mimosas…

Jasmine: Is there something you're not telling me, Cary Anne?

Cary Anne: No, uh, it's nothing! I must have just put in the wrong address. C'mon! We were just starting to be friendly.

Jasmine: Oh no! It should take you longer than 5 minutes in a car to realize I am not a friendly person. Especially when my brother's girlfriend is sneaking around, and possibly putting his heart and his dignity on the line.

Cary Anne: Oh no, Jasmine, it's not like that. I am not sneaking around. It's just… where I'm going is kind of a secret.

Jasmine: Hmm. A non-sneaking around kind of secret?

Cary Anne: Exactly!

Jasmine: Cut the crap, Cary Anne. Your lies stink like blue cheese.

Cary Anne [sighs]: Do you promise you can keep a secret? He'll be awfully mad I told you.

Jasmine [making fun of her a bit]: Pinky promise.

[Cary Anne excitedly returns the pinky promise and then shuffles in her purse to pull out a ring]

Cary Anne: I'm going to get my engagement ring fitted! Ahhhhh!! I'm so excited, I might burst. Oh boy, it was hard to hold that one in. Josh was sweating like a pig all morning. He could barely eat his gourmet bacon, which started to make *me* nervous. And next thing I know, your sweetheart brother had slipped this diamond beauty into my drink. [**Excited]** I ALMOST CHOKED TO DEATH ON MY MIMOSA COVERED WEDDING RING! It's every girl's dream come true.

Jasmine: …Are you serious?

Cary Anne [excited screaming]: EEEEEEEEEEE!!!

Jasmine: Oh my god. Oh my god. **[leans forward]** Driver, stop the car! Just pull over here. I don't care where, just stop the car.

Cary Anne: Jazzy?

Jasmine: I need to get out of this car.

[car pulls over, Jasmine lets herself out and leans over her knees as if she's going to be sick. Cary Anne watches and rolls down the window.]

Cary Anne: Jasmine, what's wrong?

[Jasmine groans]

Cary Anne: Come on, Jasmine. The carpool driver says there's nowhere to stop. And you're going to be late for work. Please just talk to me.

Jasmine: No… no no no. I don't care about work. I'll call in sick, which wouldn't be too hard to believe right now.

Cary Anne: I can't just leave you here.

Jasmine: PLEASE! Please leave me. That's literally all I've been asking this entire time.

Cary Anne [looks around, distraught. Turns to driver] Alright, um. I'll be getting out too. I'm sorry. I hope your passengers get better. Have a nice day!

[walks over to Jasmine, who looks pale and panicked]

Cary Anne: uh Jasmine… seriously, can I get you something? How about you tell me what's wrong?

Jasmine: You know what's wrong? YOU'RE MARRYING MY BROTHER! That's what's wrong! That means I'm going to have to live with dimwit hillbilly Barbie for the rest of my life—at family reunions, during bar crawls with my brother… and what if you have children? Then I'm going to have to live with niece or nephew spawn from *you.*

Cary Anne [for once, speechless. Anger boils.]: I have been nothing but nice to you.

Jasmine: Well I HAVEN'T ASKED YOU TO! Okay? You *stole* my brother from me. And now I'll never see him.

Cary Anne: Well you're just so busy all the time—

Jasmine: I know that I'm busy, but I'm lonely. Haven't you ever heard of defense mechanisms?

Cary Anne: You know what, Jasmine? Yes. Yes, I have heard of defense mechanisms. But have you ever heard of manners? You act like being mean is a quality trait, or a quirk. But, you're hurting real people along the way. Your motivations don't justify your actions. We all have our own problems, Jasmine. And different people deal with them in different ways, but you can still be nice. You don't have to project your hatred onto other people.

Jasmine [verge of tears, knows she's right]: What?

Cary Anne: I said: Don't project your hatred onto other people.

Jasmine [taking it to heart, in tears]: Josh… Josh always says that. Oh god—I'm sorry. **[Cary Anne closes distance between them and hugs her]** I'm sorry.

Cary Anne: It's okay. I'm sorry too. I know I drove a wedge between you two. He says he misses you, you know? He says you two used to be so close after your parents' divorce.

Jasmine: Yeah… he used to take care of me. I was 12. He kept me from releasing my volatile emotions on the world. And he *always* said that… about the projecting.

Cary Anne [shoots eyebrows up playfully]: He says it to me too.

Jasmine: You? You're always so happy. What are you projecting, unicorn dust?

Cary Anne: Mmmm… you should see me when he tells me to “calm” “down”. **[both laugh]**

Jasmine: So… I’ll probably be late for work today.

Cary Anne: Sugar, I wouldn’t be surprised if you get fired.

Jasmine [surprised at her bluntness, but kind of impressed]: Look at you, picking up on some of my grumpiness. You’re a lot like my brother, you know? I’m really happy for you.

Cary Anne: Thank you, Jazzy.

Jasmine: I’ll call my boss. I think I’m still going to take a sick day today.

Cary Anne: Really? Why?

Jasmine: Well, we have a ring fitting to get to.

Cary Anne [shocked, excited]: You’re not serious!

Jasmine [putting on an accent]: Serious as an alligator in a cornfield in Arkansas.

Cary Anne: EEEEEE! **[hugs her]** This is so going to be so much fun! **[checks phone]** Oh no, there’s no Quick Ride Carpool in sight for another 20 minutes.

Jasmine [shrugs]: That’s okay. We’ll do it Big Apple style. **[puts an arm on Carry Anne’s shoulder]** We’ll take the subway.